

The Transition Advocate is an independent role, appointed by the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, to support the transition away from live sheep exports by sea.

The role provides independent advice and two-way communication between the Australian sheep industry and government, with a focus on Western Australia.

The Transition Advocate works to support producers, businesses and communities to access the information they need to prepare for the trade's end, whilst informing and providing advice to government on how the industry is progressing.

The Transition Advocate is funded as part of the \$139.8 million transition assistance package.

Meet the Transition Advocate



Dr Chris Rodwell is an Australian veterinarian and biosecurity expert with a distinguished career spanning senior roles in Western Australia, the Commonwealth Government and New Zealand.

Based in Western Australia, he has built a reputation for leadership in agricultural exports, animal welfare, disease preparedness and large-scale sector reform. Dr Rodwell was appointed as the Transition Advocate on 6 February 2025 and will serve until 30 June 2029.

As Transition Advocate, Dr Rodwell provides information to stakeholders about the transition plan and available assistance and offers independent advice to government on transition progress.

Dr Rodwell is known for his ability to synthesise complex information and communicate clearly across industry, government and community audiences. He views the transition away from live sheep exports by sea as an opportunity to shape a strong and sustainable future for Australia's sheep industry.

Current activities

Since his appointment, Dr Rodwell has focused on engaging with producers, businesses and leaders from across the supply chain to understand the needs of the sheep production system, current areas of tension and potential opportunities for the industry into the future.

In 2025, Dr Rodwell established a Strategic Steering Group to support the development of the [WA Roadmap to 2028](#) and maximise impact for the on-the-ground implementation, including:

- Providing guidance on the industry strategy and priority action plan for Western Australia's sheep and wool sector
- Identifying analysis or work required to inform and support the strategy and action plan
- Identifying potential issues or barriers to a successful transition
- Facilitating and amplifying connections between organisations, groups and networks with relevant resources and opportunities

The group's members, appointed by Dr Rodwell, are respected industry leaders with a deep understanding of the Western Australia sheep sector:

Member	Short Biography
Ms Bindi Murray – Sheep & wool producer	Ms Murray is a commercial farmer and sheep producer based in Woodanilling, Western Australia and Chair of Sheep Producers Australia. Ms Murray also currently holds Non-Executive Director roles in the Red Meat Advisory Council and Sheep Industry Health and Welfare Trust.
Ms Erin Gorter, Rural industry consultant	Ms Gorter is a rural industry consultant and a non-executive Director of both Australian Grain Technologies and the Grower Group Alliance. Ms Gorter also serves on the Council for Australian Arab Relations and is Chair of the Mt Burdett Rural and Regional Advancement Foundation committee.
Mr Ashley Herbert, Agribusiness consultant	Mr Herbert is a highly regarded farm management consultant, providing professional services to Western Australian mixed farming businesses for over 3 decades. Mr Herbert is also a Director on the Rural Business Development Corporation board and a member of the Future Drought Fund Advisory Committee.

A key focus for Dr Rodwell and the Strategic Steering Group (SSG) is to provide strategic guidance on the development of a medium-long term industry strategy for the WA sheepmeat and wool industry and a priority action plan (the WA Roadmap to 2028).

Co-designed with industry, the WA Roadmap sets out a shared vision for the future for the WA sheep industry:

A confident and adaptable WA sheep industry, supporting people across a profitable supply chain to meet changing markets, strengthened by innovation, science and technology.

The WA Roadmap complements The Future Flock and is a distinct, state-specific plan, reflecting WA's priorities into the national strategy, while the national plan provides a framework that supports WA's unique actions and investments.

To access The Future Flock and the WA Roadmap to 2028 visit [The Future Flock](#) website.

Economic Analysis

The WA Roadmap is grounded in evidence-based modelling, focusing on farmgate profitability, market development, and supply chain investment.

The report WA Roadmap to 2028: Economic Analysis provides the economic foundation for the WA Roadmap and is now available on [The Future Flock](#) website, under Reports.

The WA Roadmap is also informed by the Situational Analysis of the Western Australian Sheep Industry, a snapshot of the WA supply chain and is also available on [The Future Flock](#) website.

WA Roadmap Implementation Fund

The WA Roadmap Implementation Fund is a \$5 million fund established to support implementation of the WA Sheep Industry Roadmap to 2028, helping the Western Australian sheep industry transition and adapt following the phase out of live sheep exports by sea.

[Announced on 22 July 2026](#), the fund includes the \$2.5 million Farm System Productivity Program, an open-competitive grant opportunity for not-for-profit and commercial organisations, to support projects aligned with the WA Roadmap to 2028 and benefit the broader WA sheep industry.

The program is open between 22 July and 3 September 2026, with grants from \$50,000 to \$750,000 available with no co-contribution required.

For more information, visit the [transition assistance package page](#).

Resources

Further information

For questions regarding the Transition Advocate, Strategic Steering Group, transition plan or available programs please contact transition.advocate@aff.gov.au.

Media enquiries should be directed to media@aff.gov.au.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/export/controlled-goods/live-animals/livestock/live-sheep-exports-phase-out/advocate>